information on international affairs, whatever contemporaries might have felt about the Garden Suburb and Cabinet Secretariat. Into the Foreign Office came reports from embassies all over the world, while Curzon's promotion of the government's Code and Cipher School ensured he had access to all the latest intelligence from abroad.[36] Even the Passport Control Office – which often proved useful in monitoring movements of certain persons abroad – came under the Foreign Office's remit. Curzon had control of a vast amount of information on Britain's foreign affairs, while his colleagues in government only had what the Foreign Office supplied or what they could somehow glean for themselves through alternative sources.[37] This is worth bearing in mind, for it relates to the broader question of how the Foreign Office (and Curzon) formulated policy towards southern Asia and Russia in the years after 1918. If knowledge is power, then the officials of the Foreign Office should have been well prepared to handle affairs in Persia, Afghanistan and Russia – they certainly could not blame any mistakes made on ignorance. In the end, while the Foreign Office may have felt that it had less influence after the First World War than before it, it was still the foremost repository of foreign affairs knowledge within the British government.

So far discussion of foreign policy has been rather broad. But what of southern Asia specifically? Indeed, it could be argued that part of the reason for the debate on Lloyd George-versus-Curzon stems from a focus on European affairs. If attention is shifted to South Asia, it quickly becomes apparent how significant a figure Curzon really was in the creation of Britain's foreign policy. For, given that this was the foreign secretary's area of apparent expertise, Lloyd George was quite willing to let Curzon run affairs in this region, while in turn Curzon was essentially happy to let the prime minister take the lead when it came to Europe.[38] This is not to say that there was not the occasional clash; when it came to relations with Russia, for example, Lloyd George would insist on the creation of the Anglo-Soviet Trade Agreement in 1921, despite Curzon's avid protests.[39] Yet Curzon's personality, knowledge and position of power would enable him to exercise great authority, particularly when it came to Persia.

Before his elevation to the Foreign Office, Curzon initially flexed his muscles over the Mesopotamia Administration Committee, of which he